In order to understand the dynamics of the peace policymaking process, it is necessary to explain further who has been involved in it and how decisions have been made. In the following section, I will first discuss the institutional trajectory of the peace technical team as the centre of a new peace policy community under the Thein Sein administration. Next, its piecemeal approach will be examined.

PEACE TECHNICAL TEAM AS THE CENTRE OF A PEACE POLICY COMMUNITY

The term "policy community" refers to the interactions of a group of individuals, beyond or outside the formal processes of government, that occur in the interstices between and among government agencies, interest groups, corporations, industry associations, elected officials, and other institutions and individuals (Miller and Demir 2007). Throughout this new ethnic peace process in Myanmar under the Thein Sein administration, the peace technical team, the MPC, became the heart of the peace policy community. It was formed in November 2012 with strong international assistance received with regard to technical and financial matters, especially from the European Union (Seng Maw Lahpai 2014, p. 296).

The MPC was set up to provide substantial technical assistance to the government peace team, the UPWC; and to serve as a bridge between government officials, donor governments, and INGOs for the purpose of initiating peace activities. Being formed as a mediating organization for peace initiatives, the MPC does not have executive power, but it can influence administrative decision-making through its organizational position as "a secretariat for the Myanmar Peace Committee" and enjoys direct access to decision-making on the part of the president (Burma News International 2013).

The role of the MPC is more than that of a technical team. Being a part of the government's peace committee, it serves as one of the most influential groups in providing policy input to the president. In the five years of President Thein Sein's administration, the MPC supported the president as loyalists dealing with various stakeholders for major policy-making projects in addition to peace policy, such as media reform, and foreign direct investment law reform.

The MPC was the main force behind the state-initiated peace process.